

2008-07-19 – Angeles Forest Area

Peaks: Mount Gleason, Hoyt Mountain (unofficial)

Saturday was spent hiking 7 short miles to Mount Gleason in Kim's first ever official HPS hike. (Official meaning a scheduled Sierra Club Hundred Peaks Section hike as opposed to just running up hills after me.)

Gleason is the site of LA-04, an old Nike missile base, but now all that remains on the peak are a few water tanks and the nearby builders are used as a detention center.



Sadly it was a depressing day full of sunshine and comfortable temperatures with a brief moment of excitement when we found a rattlesnake where we expected a peak log to be. No pictures or snake bites though. Well, that and the abused seam on my hiking pants (rocks can be rather abrasive) completely gave way in the parking lot which meant things were rather...breezy that day for me that day as I hiked in a makeshift skirt I made out of extra clothing.



After the official hike ended I convinced Kim and our friend Jim to grab an unofficial peak that along the road home. It's very short but a decent climb and probably accounted for about half the gain of the entire day. Also of note, the peak log on Hoyt had not been signed since I was up there with John and Christine 2 months ago.

Total for the day was a little over 10 miles.

2008-07-20 – San Geronio Area

Peaks: San Geronio, Jepson Peak, Dobbs Peak

After easy day Saturday I was ready to do something more strenuous. Fortunately one of the HPS groups was doing San Geronio which is the highpoint of Southern California at 11,499 ft. In addition the trip was to include two addition peaks and the option for a third if time allowed.

As during Kim's O2 provisional backpack several weeks ago there was once again a chance of thunderstorms up in the mountains. Unlike the previous trip this weekend didn't end with me standing on the peak looking around sadly for my thunderstorm. By Thursday night before the hike we were looking at a 40% chance of thunderstorms and the group leader had confirmed the hike would go forward.



Well, there's 40% for you.



We were just unloading the cars and hitting the restrooms before the hike when it opened up on us. We spent about 20 minutes getting rained on and listening to thunder in the distance.



It was decided to push on anyway. Rain isn't a reason not to hike in most circumstances but being on a ridge during an electrical storm is generally something to be avoided. It was decided we would head up the trail and see what conditions were like in a few hours when we reached the tree line.





We started up the slightly soggy trail and the sky cleared to the point we had to take off the rain gear because it was just too warm.

Never fear though, the weather wasn't quite done with us yet.



Somewhere around 9,000 ft we approached a rather solid looking cloud layer. Not long after we climbed into it the rain started again. It wasn't as hard this time but it was enough to get us to don rain gear once again. No thunder this time so we pushed on to the peak.



This is what it looked like in the peak area. Visibility was basically nil and we could have been on the moon for all we could see.



We reached the pike of rocks that denote the peak itself and had our lunch break. There were a number of ground squirrels running around on the rocks of the peak. They were quite brave and while I was eating I was entertained with the one trying to make friends with Mamiko above. At times I thought it was going to run up and take the sandwich right out of her hand.



Here's our hearty crowd. We actually did get some brief breaks in the clouds before we left but we never had a view.



We hit two more peaks. The first, Jepson, was rather simple outside the fact we couldn't see far enough to verify we were leaving the trail at the correct ridge. The optional peak, Charlton, would have been next but a combination of wanting to get down before dark and the fact another storm was supposed to hit us around 4 pm made us decide to descend. (For the record, I voted to do the peak anyway but you probably expected that)



Our descent wasn't to be on the trail we took up but instead a cross country route across another peak called Dobbs. To reach Dobbs you set off cross country, bag the peak, and then continue down the other side. It basically has you descending 3,000 ft in under two miles which means your knees will not like you the next day.



We popped out of the clouds and the weather actually turned sunny and a little warm. As we got close to the bottom we could see the next storm front coming in. Strangely not long after the sun disappeared behind the clouds it was back and there was no sign of the storm. Ah well.



We ended up back at the cars around 6:30 pm having done about 16 miles. Basically if we had done the extra peak we probably would have been out hiking until 10:00 pm. Maybe next time.